

Team Members:

Shivam Mishra, shivam.mishra@research.iiit.ac.in, indieconnect.in/dev/shivamishraa

Samanyu Gupta, samanyu.gupta@research.iiit.ac.in, indieconnect.in/dev/kermiit

Suryanshu Mukherjee, suryanshu.mukherjee@research.iiit.ac.in, indieconnect.in/dev/death

PLAYABLE?! CHARACTER.

PLAYABLE?! CHARACTER. is a short, comic-inspired puzzle adventure set entirely within the pages of a strange comic book.

The player takes control of the protagonist as he moves through a world filled with exaggerated characters, ridiculous events, and comic-book logic. The main objective is simple: progress through the story by solving environmental puzzles.

While the player is trying to solve puzzles and move the story forward, an absurd fight between other characters is constantly unfolding somewhere in the background. The protagonist occasionally gets distracted by it, creating small comedic moments where his priorities seem noticeably different from the player's.

As the story progresses, it becomes increasingly clear that the protagonist may not be as passive as he first appears.

Gameplay

The core gameplay revolves around manipulating the same environment between **2D and 3D forms**.

In its 2D state, the world behaves like a traditional comic panel, restricting movement and interaction to a flat plane. In its 3D state, the same world gains depth, allowing the player to move around objects and interact with parts of the environment that were previously inaccessible.

Players must switch between these forms to solve environmental puzzles and progress through the comic.

The transformation itself is also part of the game's visual language. Pillars of light gradually appear around the character and close in until the screen is completely consumed by white. A page-turning sound accompanies the transition, after which the world reappears in its new form.

The puzzles are designed to remain short and understandable, keeping the focus on the story and the unusual relationship between the player and the protagonist.

Story and Twist

At first, the protagonist appears to be an ordinary playable character following the player's commands.

Small inconsistencies gradually challenge this assumption. He may look toward the fight happening in the background, hesitate before moving, or occasionally perform a small action that the player did not intend.

These moments are subtle enough to be dismissed at first.

Near the end of the game, the player discovers the truth: **the protagonist was never completely under their control.**

He had been willingly allowing the player to control him because he did not actually want to be the main character. Instead, he wanted to experience the story from inside it without having to personally play the role of its protagonist.

The player was simply his way of experiencing the adventure.

The final sequence reinforces this through gameplay rather than relying entirely on dialogue. After the last transition, the player attempts to move the protagonist, but nothing happens. After a moment, the protagonist moves on his own.

He finally gets to do what he wanted all along:

watch the story, even his own story.

Theme Integration

Comic is the foundation of the game. The world, characters, dialogue, visual effects, transitions, and presentation are designed around comic-book conventions.

Light is both a visual theme and a core gameplay mechanic. It represents the transformation between the 2D and 3D versions of the world and is used consistently throughout the experience.

Twist is built into the player's relationship with the protagonist. What initially appears to be a conventional player-character relationship is gradually revealed to be something else entirely.